moisture stress from deficit rainfall and persistently high temperatures. Precipitation has remained highly variable, alternating between heavy rains and dry spells. Diminished carryover stocks from last year and delayed start of the *primera* and *postrera* seasons will extend market dependence among poor households. While losses are less severe than last year when Tropical Storm Sara disrupted *postrera* crops in eastern El Salvador, erratic rainfall continues to disproportionally affect subsistence farmers lacking irrigation, while medium and large-scale farmers remain better equipped to manage these conditions.

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- Staple grain prices decreased this month following the end of the *primera* season, particularly for white maize and red beans. **Despite this seasonal decrease, staple grain prices remain significantly above historical norms due to regional production deficits and high input costs.** Even with generally favorable production outcomes, below-average import volumes are contributing to persistently high white maize prices, which remain 30 percent higher than the five-year average, while red bean prices remain nearly 20 percent above the average, driven primarily by losses from the 2024 *postrera* harvest. High food prices continue to erode purchasing power, especially for poor urban households who rely heavily on market purchases. Annual inflation remains below 5 percent, driven by rising costs for housing, food, and utilities. While inflation has moderated, elevated staple grain prices, particularly white maize, continue to strain household purchasing power.

- **Labor demand for coffee harvesting from November to February is expected to be normal this year**, providing critical income opportunities for poor households during the high labor season. Remittances remain an important source of income, with over 25 percent of Salvadoran households receiving remittances in 2024, including 22 percent of poor households and 5 percent of very poor households. Remittances are projected to grow moderately by year-end, though at slower pace than in early 2025, when increases were driven by U.S. immigration policy changes and the announced 1 percent remittance tax. Together, these income sources will support food access for poor rural households through February 2026.

- **An average start of the *primera* season is expected, with average rainfall through March 2026,** though above-average temperatures may increase risks of crop diseases and water stress for smallholder farmers. From April 2026, food security conditions are expected to deteriorate as households' food stocks are depleted, and labor opportunities decline during the lean season. Many poor households will likely resort to negative coping strategies, such as spending savings, purchasing food on credit, consuming less preferred foods, and reducing meal frequency or portion